



culture has matured. There's a shared goal now — to win medals, yes, but also to support each other as professionals. It felt fresh and meaningful.

I always make it a point to speak to as many people as I can in the warm-up area — not because I'm overly social, but because I'm curious. I like to know what people are up to, and honestly, I enjoy a little masala. It helps me feel grounded and human before the chaos of competition.

That day, I bumped into the distance crew — Gulveer (Singh) and his gang — mellow as ever, quietly doing their thing in endless loops. Then, in stark contrast, were the 4x100m boys: loud, wild, full of energy. In a surprising twist, the usually boisterous throwers like Yashveer (Singh), Samardeep (Singh Gill), and Sachin (Yadav) were unusually quiet, focused on their work. And then there's my personal favourite duo: Pooja and Abhinaya (Rajarajan) — the firebrand next-gen of Indian athletics. Bubbly, expressive, full of energy, and always chatting. Their energy is contagious.

After a good warm-up, some laughs, and a lot of banter, I reminded myself: "You still have to compete tomorrow." So, I made my way back to the hotel, full of warmth from the team but ready to crawl into my cocoon.

My small core team had arrived by then — Wayne (S&C), Siddhi (wife), Avantika (sister), and Devesh (friend).

We had a quick team meeting that night to go over logistics. Wayne handled my supplements and recovery protocols, Devesh was in charge of food and logistics for the day, Siddhi and Avantika were responsible for shoe changes, videography, and coaching cues during events. Everyone had a role, and they played it perfectly.

That night was all about quiet preparation. Laying out the shoes, recovery tools, clothes, equipment, and food for the day. I had already done a venue recce the morning before, so I knew exactly where everything was. After dinner, I said my good-nights and turned off the lights by 9 pm. I had to be up at 5 am the next day — the decathlon was waiting.

I went to bed, ready to compete, mind buzzing with the possibilities the next day might hold. I woke up, I felt fresh and energetic. But just as I was about to get out of bed, I glanced at the clock.

12 a.m.

What?

Only three hours of sleep. I thought the whole night had passed. From that point on, I was wide awake — not with panic, but with relentless thought. Nothing I did could lull me back to sleep. Just thoughts, thoughts, and more thoughts. This wasn't new; it's happened to me before, especially before big meets. So, I didn't panic. But I *needed* to sleep — and that was the one thing I

It's complicated: 'My relationship with the discus is like that of two old friends who respect each other but rarely get along.' ASIAN ATHLETICS

couldn't force.

Twisting and turning, counting imaginary sheep and permutations, I mentally simulated the decathlon a hundred different ways. If I do *this* in long jump, then *that* will happen in 400m... if I nail high jump, I can afford *this* in javelin... It just wouldn't stop. Finally, somewhere around 4:30, I dozed off — only for my alarm to go off at 5.

Showtime.

I had to be up — give my body at least four hours to wake up before the 9 am start. I did my morning routine, grabbed the bag I had packed the night before, picked up six 1-litre bottles of water, and headed down for breakfast. Forced down a meal at 6 am., chased it with a few cups of coffee to kick-start this diesel engine I had become, and reached the track by 7:15.

Decathlon warm-ups are different.

I prefer to do one long, comprehensive warm-up at the start of the day to save energy between events. That way, all I need before each event is a short activation — and I'm good to go.

The sun was already glaring — way too bright for that time. The birds were chirping. The athletes were buzzing around the warm-up track. And then:

"First call for men's decathlon 100m."

Nerves? Under control. Body? Felt fast, sharp. But something was off.

I wasn't excited.

This moment — nine months of preparation, sacrifice, blood and sweat — and I would rather be in bed?

That was odd.

But there is no time for introspection. Time to execute.

We lined up in the call room. Usually, I'm buzzing before the 100m. It sets the tone for the two days. A fast, snappy start tells me I'm ready. The gun went off — I felt a slightly sluggish start, but powered through the drive phase, hit top-end speed.